ThinkHub

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How Do Satellites Work?

The Technology Connecting Our World

Communication | Navigation | Weather | Earth Observation



Daksh Khandelwal

Founder, ThinkHub



Navigation

Mapping, live traffic, and vehicle routing.



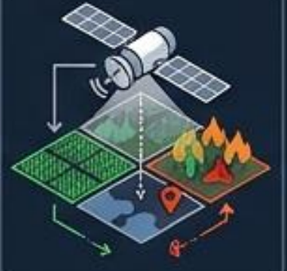
Weather

Cyclone tracking and daily forecasts.



Communication

Live television broadcasting and global connectivity.



Earth Observation

Agricultural monitoring and disaster response.

Thousands of kilometers of essential technological infrastructure are completely invisible to the naked eye.

Gemini Notebook

Natural Satellites



- **Example:** Earth's Moon.
- **Origin:** Naturally occurring bodies.
- **Function:** No designed mission; governed purely by astrophysics.

Artificial Satellites



- **Example:** GPS or Communication machines.
- **Origin:** Human-made, engineered spacecraft.
- **Function:** Built with specialized payloads to perform highly specific orbital tasks.

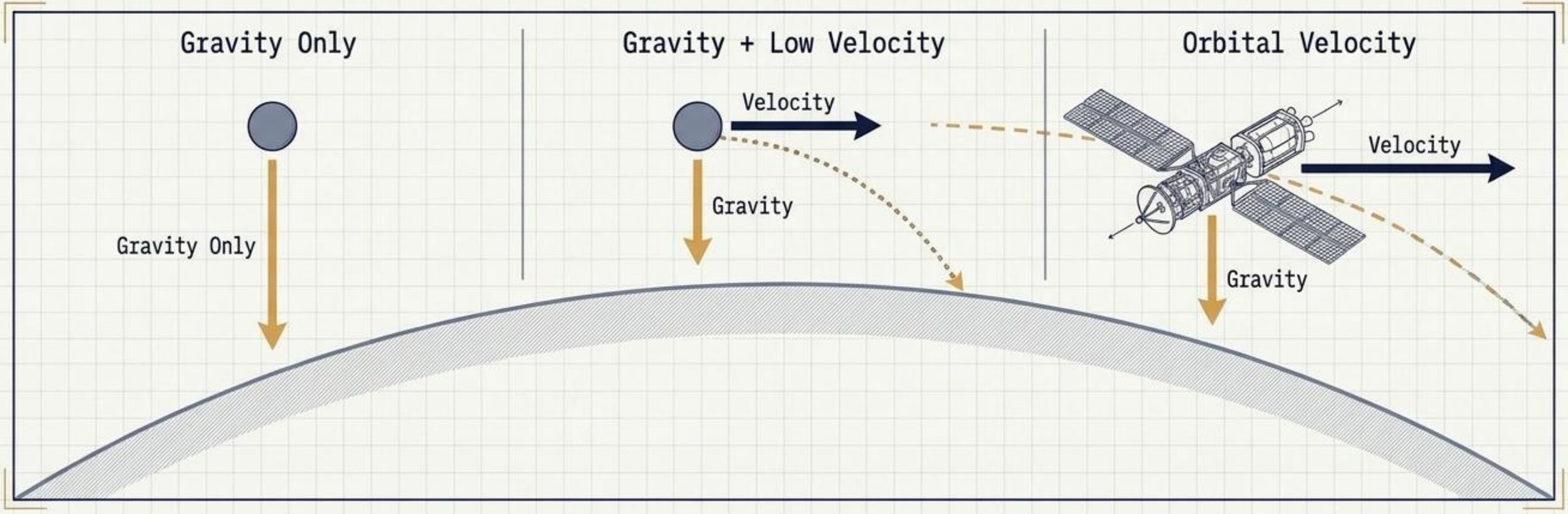
A satellite is any object that continuously revolves around a larger body due to gravitational pull.

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Aerospace Technical Whitepaper

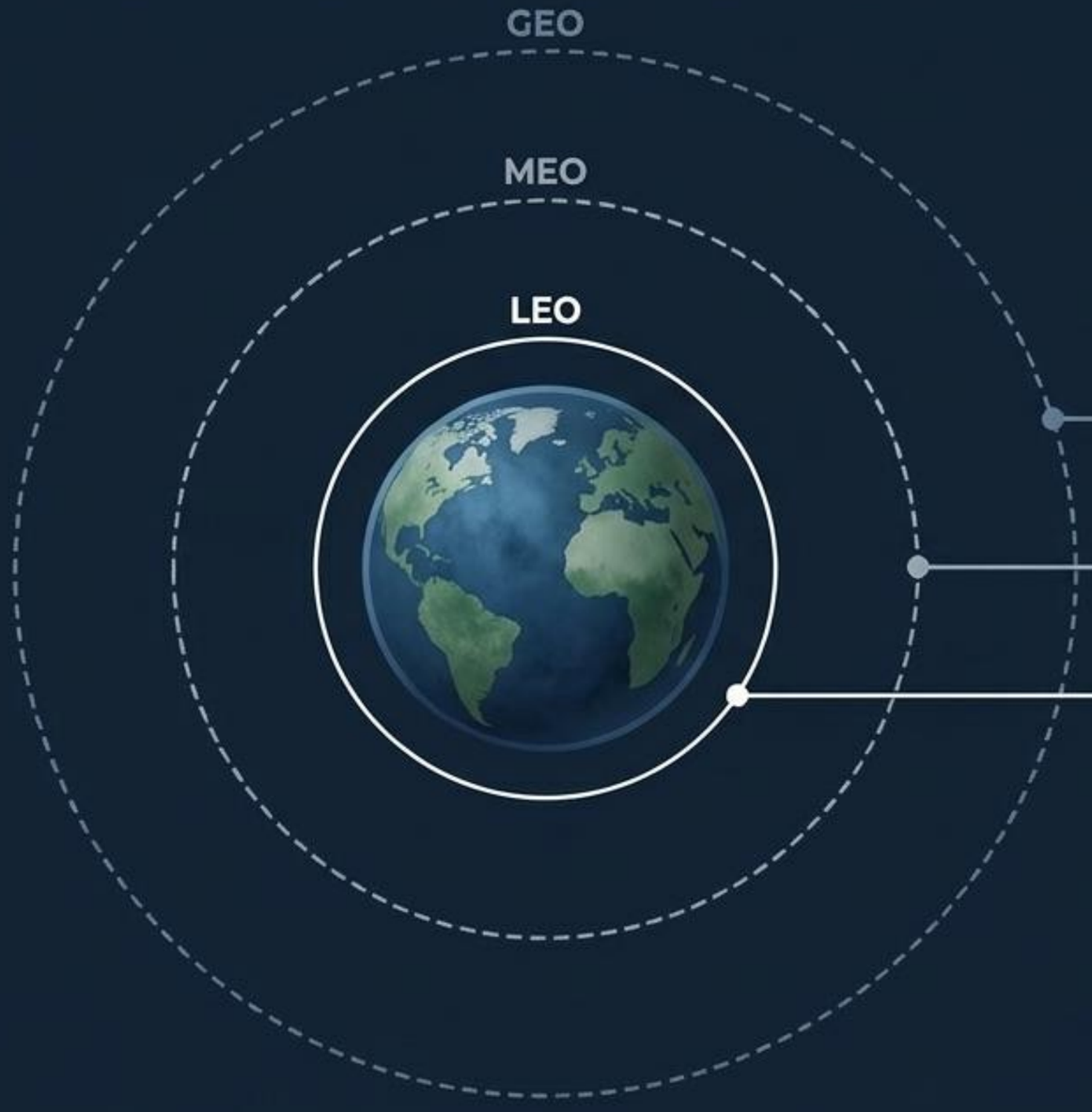
How Do Satellites Stay Up Without Falling?

A common misconception is that there is no gravity in space. In reality, Earth's gravity continuously pulls satellites downward. However, a satellite possesses immense **sideways velocity**. As it falls toward Earth, the curved surface of the planet falls away beneath it at the exact same rate. It does not escape gravity; it **continuously falls** around the Earth instead of onto it.



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The Three Zones of Orbital Operations



Outer Ring (GEO): Geostationary Earth Orbit

- **Altitude:** 35,786 km.
- **Pace:** Matches Earth's rotation, appearing stationary over a fixed point.
- **Applications:** Direct-to-home television, constant weather monitoring.

Middle Ring (MEO): Medium Earth Orbit

- **Altitude:** 2,000–35,786 km.
- **Pace:** Medium orbital periods.
- **Applications:** Global Positioning System (GPS) constellations.

Inner Ring (LEO): Low Earth Orbit

- **Altitude:** 160–2,000 km.
- **Pace:** Moves rapidly relative to the surface.
- **Applications:** High-resolution observation, satellite internet (e.g., Starlink).

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Four Missions Driving Space Architecture



Communication (Connectivity)

Transmits television, telephone, and internet signals across isolated locations and oceans.



Navigation (Positioning)

Broadcasts highly precise timing and orbital data to calculate exact global coordinates.



Weather (Atmospheric Monitoring)

Observes cloud movements, moisture distribution, and developing storm systems.



Earth Observation (Understanding the Planet)

Collects detailed optical and radar data on vegetation, oceans, and natural disasters.

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Anatomy of an Orbital Machine

Power & Storage

Solar Panels: Generate operational electricity from sunlight.

Batteries: Store energy to keep systems running in Earth's shadow.

Control & Movement

Onboard Computer: The central nervous system controlling all operations.

Reaction Wheels: Internal gyroscopes that adjust the satellite's pointing direction.

Thrusters: Propulsion for physical orbital adjustments and corrections.



Mission Execution

Payload: The specialized equipment (cameras, sensors) that performs the primary job.

Antennas: Transmit mission data and receive ground commands.

Thermal Control: Shields components from the extreme temperature swings of open space.

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Inside a Satellite: Anatomy of a Spacecraft

An exploded view revealing the critical subsystems that enable mission success.



Solar Panels & Batteries

Generate electricity from sunlight and store energy for passes through Earth's shadow.

Structure

The physical chassis holding all subsystems together during launch and operation.

Thermal Control

Radiators and blankets that maintain operational temperatures in extreme space environments.

Antennas

Receive uplink commands and transmit downlink data to ground stations.

Payload

The specialized equipment (cameras, radar, transponders) performing the main mission.

Onboard Computer

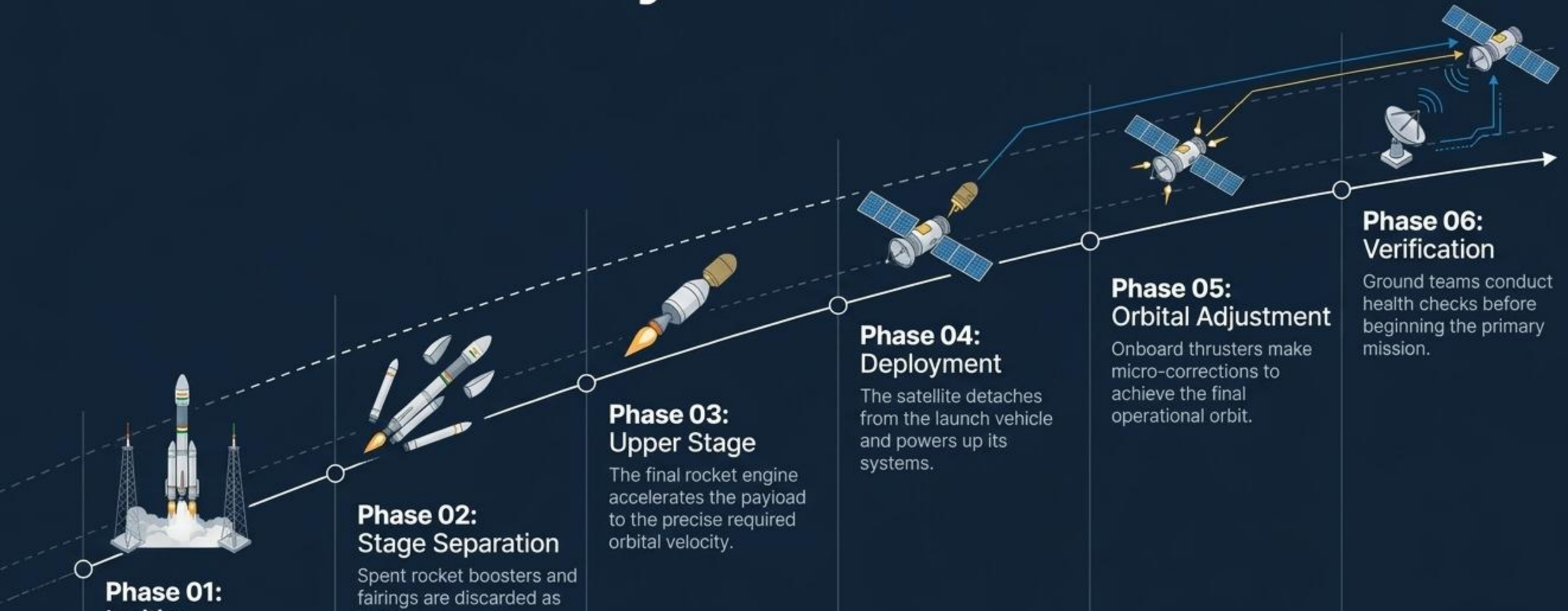
The central processor controlling operations and executing commands.

Attitude Control & Thrusters

Reaction wheels adjust the pointing direction, while thrusters make physical orbital adjustments.

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The Journey From Ground to Orbit



Phase 01:
Ignition

The multi-stage launch vehicle (e.g., ISRO's GSLV-F16) lifts off, overcoming gravity with immense thrust.

Phase 02:
Stage Separation

Spent rocket boosters and fairings are discarded as fuel is consumed to reduce weight.

Phase 03:
Upper Stage

The final rocket engine accelerates the payload to the precise required orbital velocity.

Phase 04:
Deployment

The satellite detaches from the launch vehicle and powers up its systems.

Phase 05:
Orbital Adjustment

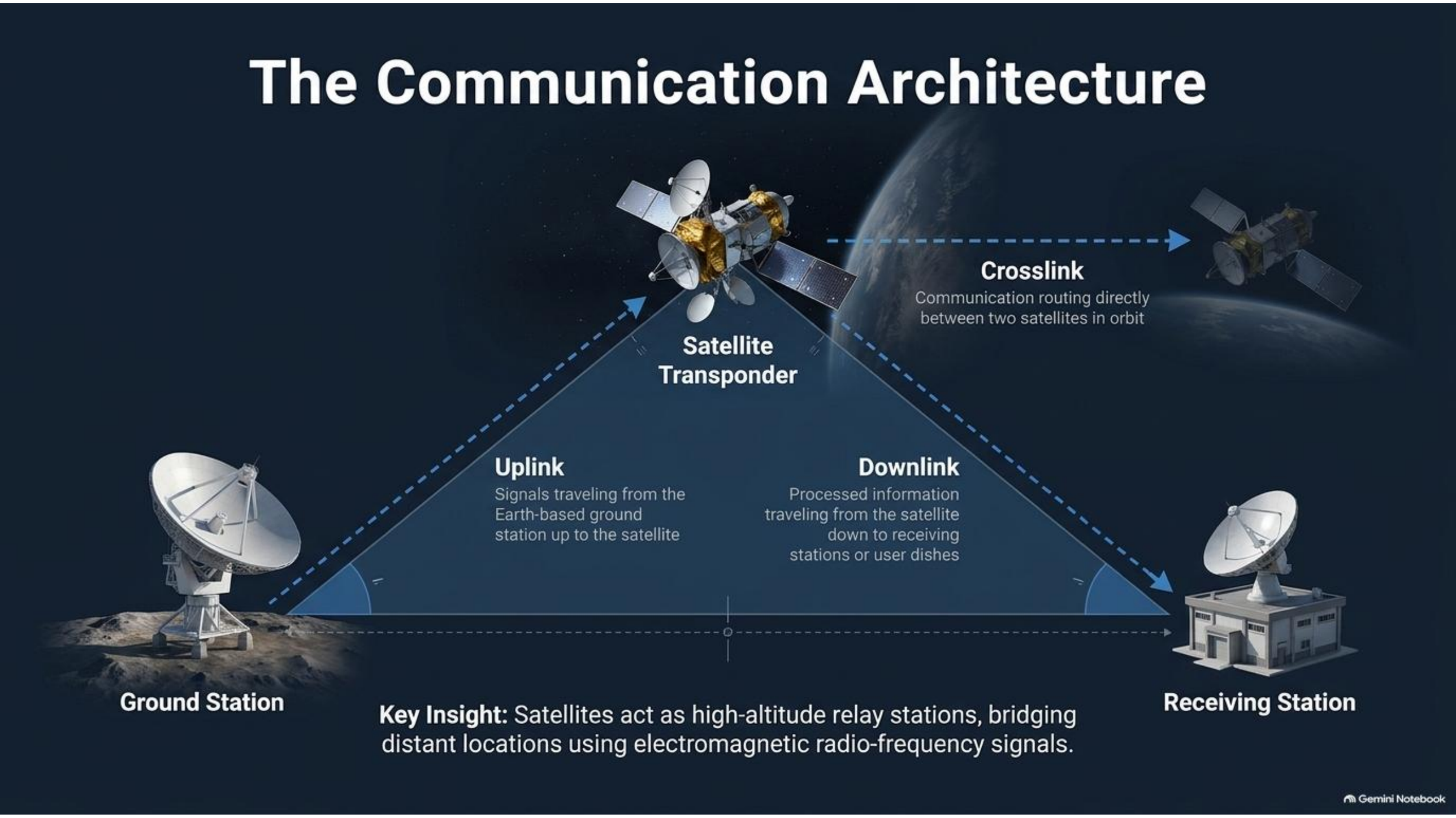
Onboard thrusters make micro-corrections to achieve the final operational orbit.

Phase 06:
Verification

Ground teams conduct health checks before beginning the primary mission.

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The Communication Architecture

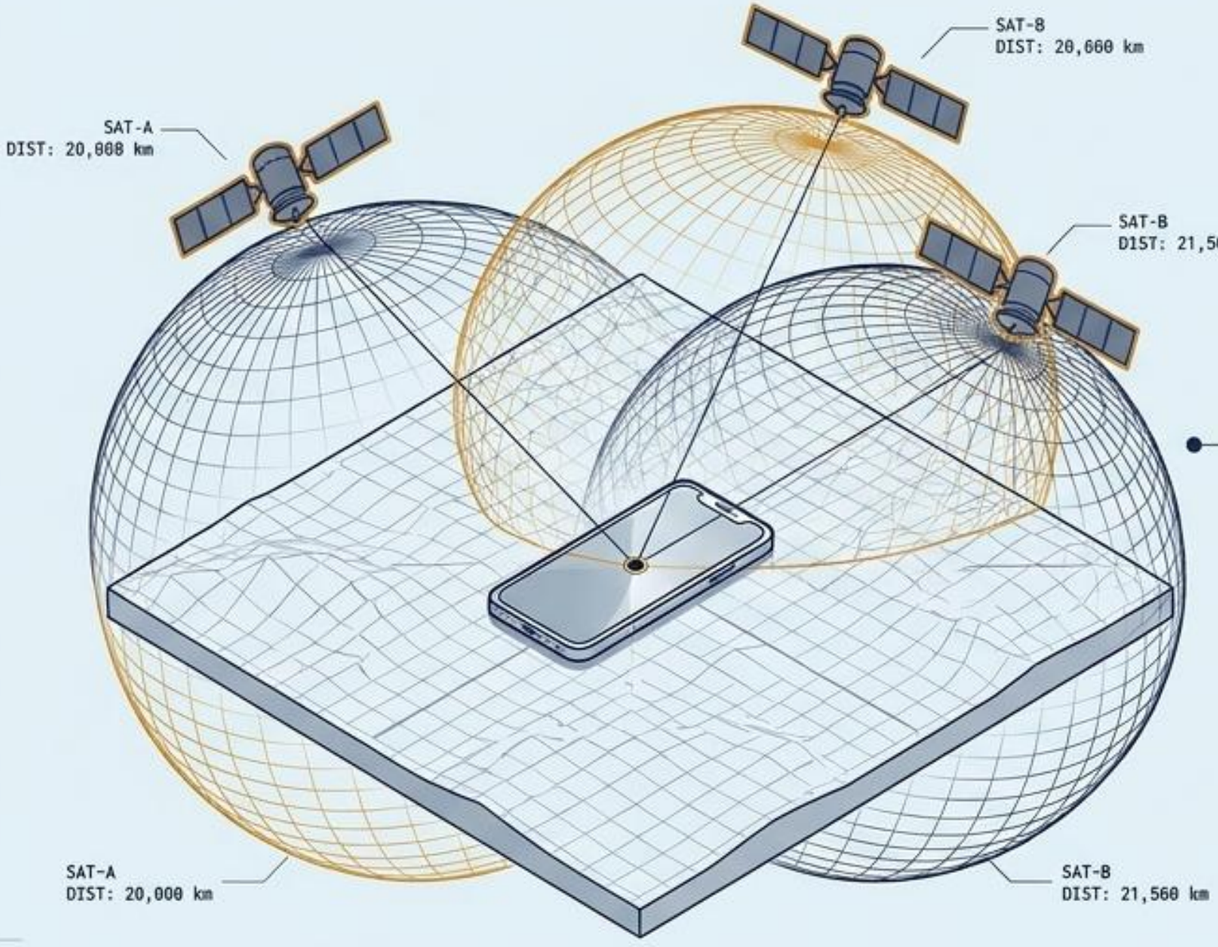


Key Insight: Satellites act as high-altitude relay stations, bridging distant locations using electromagnetic radio-frequency signals.

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How Does GPS Know Where You Are?

Crucial Distinction: GPS satellites do not track you. Your phone calculates its own position passively. Basic GPS does not require mobile internet to function.



1. The Broadcast

GPS satellites continuously transmit their exact orbital position and the precise microsecond the signal left the satellite.

2. The Measurement

Your phone's receiver measures exactly how long each signal took to arrive. Using the speed of light, it converts this time into distance.

3. Trilateration

By calculating the geometric intersection of distance spheres from at least four satellites, the phone determines its exact 3D position and corrects its internal clock.

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Observing the Earth Across Spectrums

Optical Sensors



- **Mechanism:** Captures reflected sunlight (passive).
- **Output:** High-resolution visible imagery, similar to a digital camera.
- **Limitation:** Cannot see through clouds or operate effectively at night.

Infrared Sensors



- **Mechanism:** Detects thermal radiation and near-infrared light (passive).
- **Output:** Reveals surface temperatures and vegetation health invisible to the naked eye.

Radar Instruments



- **Mechanism:** Bounces microwave signals off the surface and reads the reflection (active).
- **Output:** Structural data of terrain and water bodies.
- **Advantage:** Operates flawlessly through dense cloud cover and total darkness.

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Translating Space Signals into Human Action



Step 1: Collection.
Orbital sensors capture raw observations (images, radar, atmospheric data).



Step 2: Transmission.
The raw data is packaged and sent via downlink to a tracking antenna.



Step 3: Ingestion.
Ground stations receive and securely store the digital signal.



Step 4: Processing.
Supercomputers correct errors and translate the raw signal into usable datasets.



Step 5: Analysis.
Scientists and algorithms interpret the data to extract specific insights.



Step 6: Application. The finalized data powers user applications—producing flood maps, weather warnings, and crop health alerts.

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India’s Orbital Infrastructure (ISRO)

INSAT System (Communication & Meteorology)



- **Profile:** India's backbone for telecommunications, television broadcasting, and disaster warning.
- **Recent Tech:** INSAT-3DS (launched 2024) utilizing advanced imagers and sounders for precise weather monitoring.



NavIC (Regional Navigation)



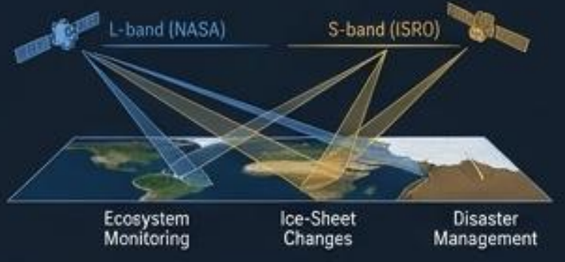
- **Profile:** India's independent, sovereign positioning system.
- **Coverage:** Dedicated constellation covering the Indian mainland and extending 1,500 km beyond its borders for maritime and transport routing.



NISAR (Earth Observation)



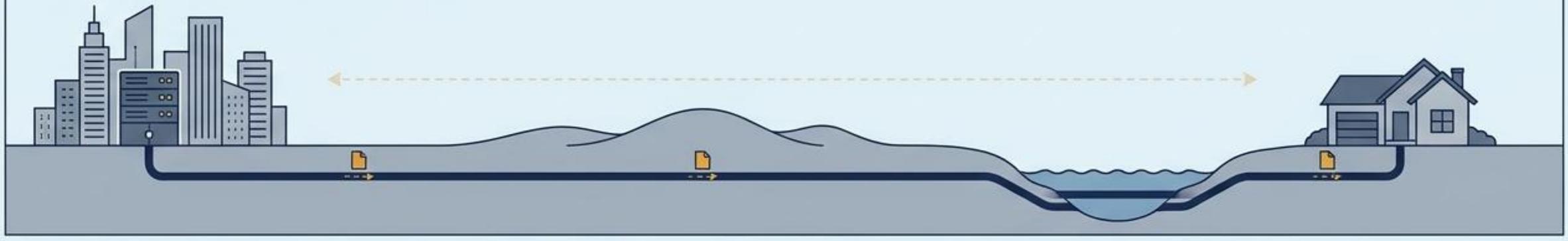
- **Profile:** A landmark 2025 joint mission between NASA (L-band radar) and ISRO (S-band radar).
- **Function:** Advanced dual-frequency synthetic aperture radar capable of monitoring minute ecosystem and ice-sheet changes globally.



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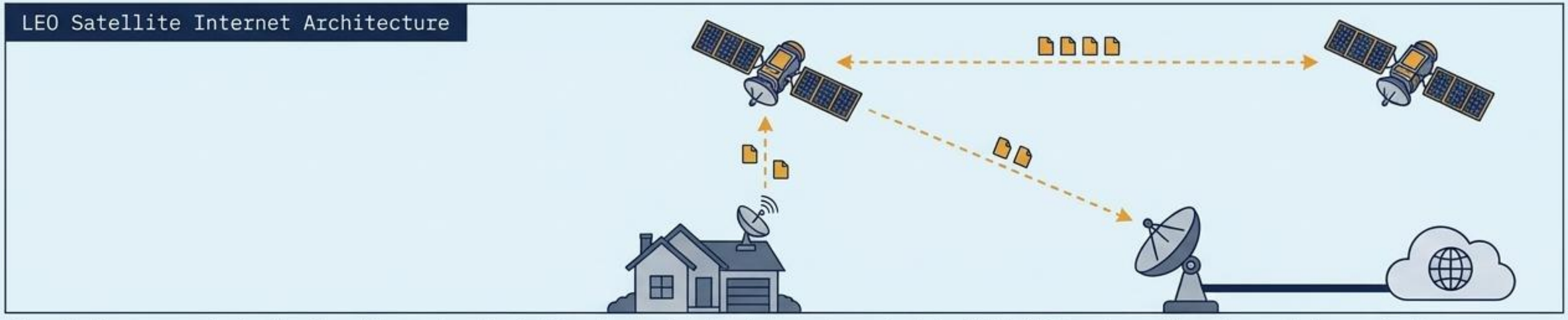
Satellite Internet: Can Space Connect Everyone?

Traditional Broadband Infrastructure



Relies on physical ground infrastructure. Offers low latency, but is incredibly difficult and expensive to deploy in remote, rural, or mountainous regions.

LEO Satellite Internet Architecture



Terminals communicate directly with overhead satellites, bypassing local ground constraints. While LEO reduces the extreme latency of older systems, performance can be hindered by heavy weather, structural obstructions, or shared network capacity.

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Congestion and the Kessler Syndrome

The Hazard:

Defunct satellites, discarded rocket stages, and collision fragments travel at hyper-velocity speeds, turning small debris into lethal projectiles.



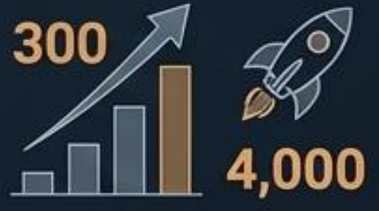
The Kessler Syndrome:

A theoretical tipping point where an initial collision creates a debris field, triggering a cascading chain reaction of further collisions that could render specific orbits entirely unusable.



The 2025 Reality (ESA Data):

Over **300 launches** and **4,000 new payloads** entered an already crowded orbital environment in a single year.





Solutions:

Space sustainability requires active debris removal, mandatory end-of-life disposal plans, and global space traffic coordination.



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The Digital Web Surrounding Our World

Synthesis Statement: Satellites are not isolated machines floating in a void. They are an integrated, invisible extension of Earth's infrastructure.

The Ecosystem: From complex rocket propulsion and precise orbital mechanics to downlink data processing, this technology functions as a singular, highly coordinated system.



We rely on this deep-space blueprint every time we check a forecast, route a map, or connect across oceans. Space technology is no longer distant from our lives; it is the foundation of them.

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THINK. LEARN. GROW.

THANK YOU!

The future belongs to those who build it continuously.

START TODAY.
Take the first step.

STAY CONSISTENT.
Small steps, big results.

BUILD ONE PROJECT
at a time.



PRESENTED BY

DAKSH KHANDELWAL

FOUNDER, THINKHUB

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